saying that both societies need to ask themselves, much more than they do, what they should care about in the borderlands and why. As things stand both peoples know they care about their claims, but few know exactly what those claims are and why they are important.

With Indian academics and officials, I am careful in raising the subject of what is sensible and what is phantasmagorical in the borderlands, fearing accusations of being a 'liberal' and perhaps even a 'panda hugging' China-appeaser. Few even among India's strategists or small tribe of 'China hands' want to ask too many questions about the real importance of the various territorial claims. The experts all have thoughts on what is to be done with China in the here and now, but the origins and unfolding of the quarrel over time are hazy and complicated, and not even those who have seen the files on it are terribly clear. Understandably, for decision-makers, the border areas in contention are important because they are important – the question is how to resolve or, even more so, manage the dispute.

One year, at a conference in Shanghai, I fell into step with a Chinese colleague and realized that it is much the same in China – the hazy knowledge of complicated interactions and lack of clarity about why the two countries had quarrelled so bitterly. As we walked out of the seminar room, he and I talked about our memories of 1962. I was seven years old, in London, and I remembered the strained silence at home during the four weeks of the war, as India faced defeat. The winter of 1962 was one of the coldest in London's history. The pipes in our home froze. My father was at the embassy a lot; my mother was unwell. I was telling my Chinese colleague rather disjointedly about those days. He remembered much less. He could not even be sure if he had any recall of the war – perhaps what he had was a 'phantom memory', one that had lodged in his mind from others who had talked or written about the war.

What was so important about the territories in question between India and China, I asked my Chinese companion? Without waiting for his answer, I followed up with another question: why had China solved all its land-border disputes except with India? I should probably not have asked the second question. He stopped and looked down at the floor: 'You know,